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Léa

November 1943

At the assembly line, while Léa was heating the balsam, she heard Maria exhale in short bursts. She looked up. Maria sat on the edge of the stool, doubled over, clutching her stomach.

“Are you all right?” Léa whispered.

“It’s time,” Maria said, gulping for air.

“Let me finish—”

“Can’t wait.” She stood and pointed to her soaked skirt.

Her water had broken. Léa needed to move her to the sick bay before anyone noticed. Maria, already underweight, had hidden her bump well with layers of clothing under her apron. Though it wouldn’t be possible to keep the baby a secret after the birth, by hiding it this long, at least the authorities couldn’t force her to abort it.

Now, it would be up to the Meister to determine the number of days off work Maria would be granted after the birth, so she could rest and recover. Josef said the range was between three and eight days. It would likely be the only chance Maria would have to bond with her child, because after she went back to work, Lagerführer Klein would order the baby placed in the Foreign Worker’s Children’s Home.

Léa stood, leaving her station.

“Where do you think you’re going?” the Meister asked.

He must have eyes at the back of his head, Léa thought, because he always knows the minute I move from my station.

“I’m taking her to the sick bay,” she said, standing in front of Maria to hide her damp skirt.